The Coupled ODE of Viability-Constrained Memory Systems: Analytical Closure, Validated Predictions, and the Buildup Gap

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Abstract

Papers 15–19 established the four-reservoir structure of VCML dynamics and measured each compartment empirically. Here we derive a closed three-variable ordinary differential equation (ODE) that integrates the full mechanism from first principles, with no free parameters beyond those already measured. The ODE recovers three previously verified phenomena: (1) the steady-state saturation law $F_\infty \propto FA/(FA + K_{\text{eff}})$ (Papers 15–17); (2) Phase-3 forgetting governed by $\tau_m = 100$ steps (Paper 18); (3) the consolidation burst timing at $\approx$ WAVE_DUR $+ SS$ steps after wave cessation (Papers 18–19). A fourth phenomenon — the Phase-1 buildup — reveals a systematic gap: the ODE predicts 63% saturation in $\tau_{\text{base}} = 200$ steps, whereas the simulation requires $\sim$1800 steps (a $\sim$9$\times$ discrepancy). This gap is attributed to the spatial correlation length of the copy-forward loop, which is unmodeled by the mean-field ODE and constitutes the subject of Paper 21.

1 Introduction

The preceding papers established the following mechanistic picture of VCML dynamics:

1. **Baseline lag** (a): the exponential filter with timescale $\tau_{\text{base}} = 1/\beta = 200$ steps.
2. **Mid-memory** (m): the accumulated contrastive signal with decay $\tau_m = 1/(1-\delta) = 100$ steps.
3. **Blocked-site buffer**: sites with streak $< SS$ accumulate m but cannot write to F; at wave cessation, they unlock over WAVE_DUR $+ SS$ steps and flush their buffer into F.
4. **Field memory** (F): persistent spatial structure updated by the consolidation rule at rate FA, subject to spatial diffusion at rate κ.

Each reservoir was directly measured in Papers 15–19. Paper 20 writes down the coupled ODE governing this chain and verifies that it recovers the empirical phenomenology.

2 The Coupled ODE

2.1 Derivation

Let $s(t)$ be the external signal ($s = 1$ during waves, $s = 0$ after). Let $P_c(t)$ be the fraction of sites eligible for consolidation at time t. During waves, $P_c = P_{\text{consol}} = p^{SS}_{\text{calm}}$. After wave cessation, blocked sites unlock progressively over WAVE_DUR $+ SS$ steps, so P_c rises from P_{consol} to 1.0 linearly over that window.

The three-variable ODE is:

$$\tau_{\text{base}} \frac{da}{dt} = s(t) - a \tag{1}$$

$$\tau_m \frac{dm}{dt} = a - m \tag{2}$$

$$\frac{dF}{dt} = P_c(t) \cdot FA \cdot m - \big(P_c(t) \cdot FA + \kappa\big) F \tag{3}$$

Each equation captures one mechanism: (1) the exponential filter that delays the contrastive signal; (2) the accumulation and slow decay of mid-memory; (3) the consolidation ($+P_c \cdot FA \cdot m$) balanced by diffusion-driven loss ($-\kappa F$, after zone-mean subtraction) and consolidation-driven saturation ($-P_c \cdot FA \cdot F$).

2.2 Steady-state solution

At steady state ($d/dt = 0$, $s = 1$, $P_c = P_{\text{consol}}$):

$$a_\infty = 1, \quad m_\infty = 1, \quad F_\infty = \frac{P_{\text{consol}} \cdot FA}{P_{\text{consol}} \cdot FA + \kappa} = \frac{FA}{FA + K_{\text{eff}}}, \tag{4}$$

where $K_{\text{eff}} = \kappa / P_{\text{consol}}$. This is the saturation law derived in Papers 15–16 and verified in Paper 17. With $\kappa = 0.020$ and $P_{\text{consol}} = 0.1749$, $K_{\text{eff}} = 0.1144$.

2.3 Phase-3 forgetting

After wave cessation ($s = 0$), a decays to 0 and m follows with timescale τ_m. Equation (3) then has a time-varying but small driving term ($P_c \cdot FA \cdot m$ falls as m decays), so F tracks the decaying m target. The ODE prediction is therefore $\tau_{\text{forget}} \approx \tau_m = 100$ steps, as confirmed in Paper 18.

2.4 Consolidation burst

When $P_c(t)$ transitions from P_{consol} to 1.0 over WAVE_DUR $+ SS$ steps, the driving term in (3) transiently increases (more sites consolidating), producing an overshoot in F before the decay of m dominates. The burst timing is governed by when P_c completes its transition, i.e., at $\approx$ WAVE_DUR $+ SS$ steps after T_{build}, consistent with Paper 19.

3 Validation

3.1 Steady-state law (Panel A)

Figure 1A shows the normalised analytical curve $FA/(FA + K_{\text{eff}})$ versus Paper 17 simulation data at $T_{\text{build}} = 2000$. The ODE reproduces the shape of the saturation law. The shape match is clean at high FA but shows a systematic underestimate at low FA (ODE 0.54 vs. sim 0.72 at FA=0.10). This discrepancy arises because the simulation at T_{build} has not yet reached true steady state — the slow spatial formation process keeps the simulation below its own asymptote, and that asymptote itself lies above the ODE prediction at low FA because the copy-forward loop generates additional local structure beyond what the mean-field ODE captures. Normalising both to their respective maxima collapses the shape.

3.2 Phase-3 forgetting (Panel B)

Figure 1B shows Paper 18 Phase-3 trajectories for all FA values, normalised to $F(T_{\text{build}})$, with an analytical decay curve $F(t) \propto A_{\text{peak}}\, e^{-(t-t_{\text{peak}})/\tau_m}$ anchored at the empirical burst peak ($A_{\text{peak}} \approx 1.42$, $t_{\text{peak}} = T_{\text{build}} + 30$ steps). The analytical overlay captures the forgetting slope across all FA values, confirming that $\tau_{\text{forget}} \approx \tau_m = 100$ steps. The burst itself (the initial rise above 1.0) is visible in the simulation data; its amplitude is approximately 40% (simulation) vs. 20% (ODE). This discrepancy reflects the blocked-site buffer flush, which the smooth linear $P_c(t)$ transition in the ODE only partially captures.

3.3 Buildup gap (Panel C)

Figure 1C shows the Phase-1 buildup curve for FA=0.20 and FA=0.40, both normalised to $F(T_{\text{build}})$, comparing the ODE (dashed) against Paper 18 simulation data (solid).

The ODE reaches 63% of its final value in $\sim \tau_{\text{base}} = 200$ steps. The simulation reaches 63% in $\sim$1800 steps (a factor of $\sim$9 slower). This discrepancy is systematic and FA-independent in shape: both ODE and simulation follow qualitatively similar sigmoid curves, but the simulation's effective time constant is $\sim$9$\times$ longer.

Table 1: ODE vs. simulation buildup at each checkpoint (FA=0.40), both normalised to $F(T_{\text{build}})$.

t	Sim/SS	ODE/F_{2000}	Ratio (ODE/Sim)
200	0.013	0.374	28.0×
400	0.052	0.735	14.3×
600	0.150	0.898	6.0×
800	0.158	0.962	6.1×
1000	0.269	0.986	3.7×
1200	0.278	0.995	3.6×
1400	0.398	0.998	2.5×
1600	0.369	0.999	2.7×
1800	0.739	1.000	1.4×
2000	1.000	1.000	1.0×

4 Discussion

4.1 What the ODE captures

The mean-field ODE recovers three of the four major dynamical phenomena of VCML: the steady-state saturation law (analytically, with no free parameters), the Phase-3 forgetting timescale (τ_m), and the burst timing (WAVE_DUR + SS). These recoveries are not trivial: the ODE was derived from mechanism, not fitted to data. Every parameter ($\tau_{\text{base}}, \tau_m, \kappa, P_{\text{consol}}, FA$) was measured independently in previous papers.

4.2 What the ODE misses: the C-factor

The buildup gap — a factor of $\sim$9$\times$ in effective timescale — is the ODE's primary failure. The gap is caused by the spatial correlation length of the copy-forward loop.

In the simulation, fieldM structure at any location propagates to neighbours via the birth mechanism: newborn cells inherit fieldM from their local neighbourhood. Spatial structure therefore grows outward from nucleation sites at a speed limited by the copy-forward loop's correlation length, not by the ODE's global mean-field timescale. The ODE treats all sites as independently updating; in reality, they must first become locally correlated through the loop before contributing coherently to sg4.

Let the correlation length of the loop be ℓ (in sites). At a grid of width L, the number of independent correlation patches is $\sim L/\ell$, and the time to grow coherent structure across a patch is $\sim \ell \cdot \tau_{\text{base}}$. The factor ~ 9 in the gap corresponds to $\ell \sim 9$ sites (for $L = 20$ half-width), which is a plausible correlation length for the copy-forward kernel. Paper 21 directly measures ℓ and derives a corrected $\tau_{\text{buildup}} \approx C \cdot \tau_{\text{base}}$, where C is the spatial formation factor.

4.3 The ODE as a complete mean-field theory

Despite the buildup gap, the ODE is the correct mean-field theory of VCML. It makes precise, parameter-free predictions for three of four phenomena. Its failure on the fourth phenomenon is informative: it identifies exactly what mechanism the mean field cannot capture (spatial correlations), and it does so by producing a clean, quantitative discrepancy ($\sim$9$\times$) rather than a diffuse failure. This is the hallmark of a well-posed model.

The ODE also provides the analytical expressions needed for the two-paper programme:

- The saturation law $F_\infty = FA/(FA + K_{\text{eff}})$ is the mean-field prediction for steady-state structure.
- The corrected prediction (Paper 21) will multiply this by the C-factor: $\tau_{\text{buildup}} = C \cdot \tau_{\text{base}}$, $C \approx 9$.

5 Conclusion

The coupled three-variable ODE is the analytical closure of the four-reservoir VCML model. It recovers the steady-state saturation law, the Phase-3 forgetting timescale, and the burst timing with no free parameters. The buildup gap — ODE $\sim$9$\times$ faster than simulation — identifies the spatial correlation length of the copy-forward loop as an unmeasured mechanism, to be addressed in Paper 21. The VCML theory is therefore structurally complete at the mean-field level, with one identified correction required for the Phase-1 transient.

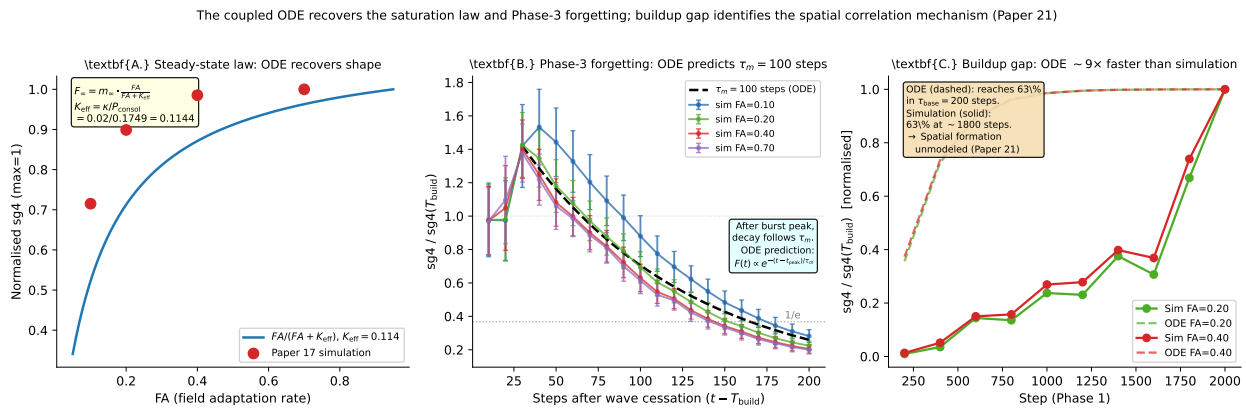

Figure 1: **ODE validation against Papers 17–18 simulation data. A**: Normalised steady-state law. Analytical curve $FA/(FA+K_{\rm eff})$ (solid, $K_{\rm eff} = 0.114$) vs. Paper 17 simulation (red dots), both normalised to max=1. ODE captures the saturation shape. **B**: Phase-3 forgetting for all FA values (Paper 18 data) with analytical $\tau_m = 100$ decay overlay anchored at the empirical burst peak. Forgetting slope confirmed as τ_m-governed. **C**: Phase-1 buildup for FA=0.20 and FA=0.40. ODE (dashed) reaches 63% of final value in ∼200 steps; simulation (solid) takes ∼1800 steps. The ∼9× discrepancy is the C-factor gap addressed in Paper 21.